TWO ENGLISH MUGS PODCAST

The Power of Silence

Episode 27 · Full Transcription

Emma & Josh

B1 Intermediate

EMMA: I have an honest question for you today. Like really honest.

JOSH: Oh boy. Uh, I am ready for it.

EMMA: So has anyone ever ruined a great plan just by talking about it way too much?

JOSH: Yeah. Um, I think we all do that, honestly.

EMMA: So today on the episode, we are talking about exactly that.

JOSH: Yeah. Why keeping things quiet You know, keeps your energy safe.

EMMA: We have some true stories and some very useful words today.

JOSH: Plus, uh, some upgraded sentences you can use in real life.

EMMA: And the best part is saved for last.

JOSH: But wait, keeping things quiet sounds, um, like hiding. Are we just being weird and secret?

EMMA: No, it is about the power of silence. Why saying less builds more.

JOSH: I really like that idea.

EMMA: Hello and welcome to Two English Mugs, where we learn English through real everyday conversations. I'm Emma.

JOSH: And I'm Josh.

EMMA: We are super glad you are here with us for this chat.

JOSH: Just a quick note before we jump in. So this is a B1 lesson.

EMMA: Right. It is great for daily life.

JOSH: It is not baby English at all, but it is not super hard either. It's, it's right in the exact middle.

EMMA: And we keep it very clear for you.

JOSH: Yep. If we use any new words, we will just explain them as we go. You will not get lost.

EMMA: We promise you that.

JOSH: Yep. And we also have a PDF transcript in the description.

EMMA: You can read right along with us. Let us jump right into point 1, why quiet works.

JOSH: I'm so ready to learn why I should, you know, keep my mouth shut.

EMMA: So when we talk a plan away, it costs us our push. Our drive to do the work just fades fast.

JOSH: Our drive? You mean like the energy we need to do the hard parts?

EMMA: Yes, exactly. Think of a plan like a hot spark from a fire.

JOSH: A spark is very small and, well, fragile. It needs care.

EMMA: Right. When it is new, you must block the wind. Too much wind blows it out.

JOSH: So, um, telling people is like a huge gust of wind.

EMMA: Exactly. When you tell everyone, you feel a sudden rush of joy.

JOSH: Because they tell me I am great and brave.

EMMA: But you have not done any work yet. You only talked.

JOSH: That is true. I just made a big noise.

EMMA: And that talk gives you a false win. It tricks your mind.

JOSH: It tricks my mind into feeling I already crossed the finish line.

EMMA: Yes. It is like you eat the dessert before you cook the meal.

JOSH: I do love dessert, but I see the problem. I lose my hunger for the real work.

EMMA: Let us use a daily life picture. Think of a warm soda bottle.

JOSH: Okay. A plastic bottle full of sweet fizzy soda.

EMMA: If you twist the cap just a bit, um, what happens?

JOSH: It makes a loud hiss and all the fizz leaks out into the air.

EMMA: Right. If you let the fizz out early, the soda goes flat.

JOSH: Nobody likes flat soda. It tastes dull.

EMMA: Your plan is the soda.

JOSH: Your mouth is the cap. If you open your mouth, you lose your fizz.

EMMA: So if I keep the cap tight, the pressure builds up inside.

JOSH: Yes.

EMMA: That pressure turns into a real push to act. It makes you wake up early.

JOSH: It forces me to put on my shoes and do the work.

EMMA: Exactly. When no one knows your plan, you do not get a false prize.

JOSH: Let me share a true story about this false prize.

EMMA: I would love to hear it.

JOSH: Last year, I got a wild idea to run a huge race.

EMMA: A big running race? You are not a runner, Josh.

JOSH: I know. But I bought fancy shoes, bright shorts, and a water belt.

EMMA: Did you go for a run in your new gear?

JOSH: No way! I took a shiny photo of my gear instead.

EMMA: And you put it online for everyone to see?

JOSH: Of course I did! I posted it for all my pals.

EMMA: What did they say to you?

JOSH: They loved it! They left comments like, you got this, Josh!

EMMA: How did that make you feel in the moment?

JOSH: I felt like a hero. I felt like a true athlete.

EMMA: But you still had not run a single step.

JOSH: Not one step. I sat on my couch eating salty chips.

EMMA: Because your mind already got the praise. It felt full.

JOSH: My mind got the prize. So my legs refused to work.

EMMA: That is the false win. We call that losing your push.

JOSH: So when I post my shoes online, My mind thinks the hard work is done.

EMMA: Yes. And the next day when it rains, you have zero drive to run.

JOSH: I spent all my energy on the show and I kept none for the road.

EMMA: Your plan was a secret, safe thing. By talking, you let the magic leak out.

JOSH: It is a bitter pill to swallow. I talked my dream to death.

EMMA: It happens to all of us. This brings us to point 2, the tell trap.

JOSH: The tell trap. That sounds like a deep hole I do not want to fall into.

EMMA: It is. The tell trap is what happens after you tell people. They react and the plan gets heavy.

JOSH: Heavy?

EMMA: Like a rock.

JOSH: What makes a fun plan turn heavy?

EMMA: Let me ask you this. What happened the week after you posted about your big race?

JOSH: Well, I went to work and my boss asked me, how's the running, Josh?

EMMA: How did you answer him?

JOSH: I felt hot and red. I lied and said, it's going fine.

EMMA: But inside, um, you felt a heavy guilt.

JOSH: A massive guilt. I'd not run at all.

EMMA: That guilt is the trap. Before you told him, running was just a fun dream.

JOSH: It was my own private game. No rules, no limits.

EMMA: But once you told him, it became a public test. You gave him a ticket to watch your show.

JOSH: Man, I did not want to put on a show.

EMMA: Now you owe him a good show. You have a firm time limit.

JOSH: It feels like a huge weight on my back. Now, if I quit, I fail in public.

EMMA: Yes. And that fear of failing in public freezes you.

JOSH: It really does. I hid my running shoes in a dark closet.

EMMA: They became a symbol of your public debt.

JOSH: Every time I saw them, they yelled at me. You owe us a run, Josh.

EMMA: Let me share a true story from my life to show this trap.

JOSH: Please do. I feel silly with my shoe story, so I hope yours is bad too.

EMMA: Years ago, I wanted to write a short story about a lost cat.

JOSH: A lost cat? That sounds cute. Did you write it?

EMMA: I went to a party and told all my pals about it first.

JOSH: Oh, no. I know exactly where this is going.

EMMA: I told them the whole plot.

JOSH: Okay.

EMMA: I told them the funny ending.

JOSH: What did they do? Did they laugh?

EMMA: They loved it.

JOSH: You got the false win.

EMMA: They gasped and laughed at the right parts.

JOSH: You got the claps early.

EMMA: Yes. And the next morning, I sat at my desk to write.

JOSH: Let me guess. The screen stayed blank.

EMMA: It was fully blank. My mind was empty. I had already told the best parts.

JOSH: The magic was gone. You already got the prize at the party.

EMMA: Worse, my pals kept asking me about the cat story for months.

JOSH: Hey, Emma, how's the cat? That must have hurt.

EMMA: I felt like a fraud. The plan got too heavy, so I dropped it.

JOSH: The tell trap caught you. Their reactions made the work too hard.

EMMA: Exactly. And that leads us to point 3, why they react.

JOSH: Point 3, why they react. Sometimes they do not clap at all.

EMMA: Right.

JOSH: Sometimes their first reaction is not praise.

EMMA: They act worried.

JOSH: You tell someone a shiny new plan and they frown at you.

EMMA: They cross their arms.

JOSH: They ask hard questions. They mean well. But the group talk can be toxic.

EMMA: Like my uncle.

JOSH: If I say I want to change jobs, he says, isn't that hard right now?

EMMA: Your uncle brings us to a new word. What does he really mean?

JOSH: He thinks I am taking a dumb risk. He wants me to stay safe.

EMMA: He is in a place of stagnation. That is our first big word to explain.

JOSH: Stagnation? Wait, what does that mean?

EMMA: Stagnation means feeling stuck in one place, like dirty water that does not flow. Oh,

JOSH: I get it. Like a pool of water that just sits there and gets green.

EMMA: Yes. When people are in their own stagnation, they do not like to see others move.

JOSH: Why does my moving scare them? I am just changing my own job.

EMMA: Your choice acts like a mirror. It forces them to look at their own lives.

JOSH: So my bold step makes them feel bad about being stuck.

EMMA: Yes. You shine a bright light on their lack of motion.

JOSH: Without meaning to, I make them feel guilty.

EMMA: So they try to slow you down. They toss wet logs on your new fire.

JOSH: Wet logs. That is a perfect picture.

EMMA: Your tiny fire is just starting.

JOSH: And they throw a damp log right on top. They want to put my fire out. Why are they so mean?

EMMA: It is not pure hate. They just want their room to stay cool and quiet.

JOSH: They want the best for me, but their fear gets in the way.

EMMA: We are wired to keep the group safe and the same.

JOSH: When one sheep leaves the flock, the others make loud noises.

EMMA: Come back! The grass is scary out there! It is a real social force.

JOSH: Their worry gets into my head. I start to doubt myself.

EMMA: And there's the trap. You had no doubts before you spoke.

JOSH: If my uncle says it is a bad time, I think, well, maybe he is right.

EMMA: Their doubt moves into your head.

JOSH: That is, it lives there for free.

EMMA: It lives rent-free in your brain.

JOSH: I should send them a bill.

EMMA: If you share too soon, you invite their fears into your house.

JOSH: That is why quiet works. It keeps the wet logs far away.

EMMA: This brings us to point 4. One picture that lands.

JOSH: Let us paint a picture in our minds.

EMMA: I want to tell you about the Sunday lunch.

JOSH: Sunday lunch? Sounds tasty. Did someone bring pie?

EMMA: No pie. Just a burned dream. A girl named Claire wanted to be her own boss.

JOSH: She wanted to quit her safe desk job. That is a bold move.

EMMA: She wanted to take freelance jobs. But she had no clients yet.

JOSH: Oh boy. The plan was still a tiny baby.

EMMA: It was just a theory.

JOSH: She stood up.

EMMA: But she went to a big Sunday lunch with her whole family.

JOSH: She stood up and told the whole room her grand plan, didn't she?

EMMA: She did. And imagine this picture. You walked in and handed out microphones.

JOSH: She handed out microphones to every family member. That is a vivid picture.

EMMA: She basically said, here is my life choice. Please use this mic to judge me.

JOSH: I can see it. Cousin Bob grabs the mic and yells, what about healthcare, Claire?

EMMA: Yes. And Aunt Sue takes the mic and says, it is a cold world out there.

JOSH: Uncle Tom shouts, who is going to pay your rent, Claire?

EMMA: Every word was a wet log on her fire. They gave her unsolicited advice.

JOSH: Unsolicited. That is a big word. What does it mean?

EMMA: Unsolicited means getting advice you did not ask for.

JOSH: Oh, I hate unsolicited advice. It always feels bossy.

EMMA: Claire walked in feeling like a lion, but she walked out feeling like a mouse.

JOSH: Her fire was fully put out. But why did their words hit her so hard?

EMMA: Because she had no shield. A theory cannot fight back against loud doubts.

JOSH: If she had said, I have 3 clients paying me, that would be a shield.

EMMA: Facts act as a shield.

JOSH: With no facts, her family's fears took over her mind.

EMMA: She gave them the power.

JOSH: She handed out mics too early.

EMMA: You must never hand out microphones when you are still building the stage.

JOSH: So I cannot hand out mics and I cannot post photos. What do undo?

EMMA: You must learn Point 5.

JOSH: The quiet way. Point 5. The quiet way. It sounds like a secret path.

EMMA: The quiet way means you keep the plan close, but you keep the work where you see it.

JOSH: Keep the work where I see it. You mean I track my own steps?

EMMA: Yes. If you do not track them, your mind might forget the plan.

JOSH: So I post on my bedroom wall instead of online.

EMMA: Hang a paper chart in your room. Every day you work, draw a red X.

JOSH: A big red X. I like that. It is loud, but just for me.

EMMA: When you see a chain of red marks, you build momentum.

JOSH: Momentum. That sounds like a heavy physics word. What is it?

EMMA: Momentum is the force that keeps a moving object going fast.

JOSH: Like a snowball rolling down a steep hill.

EMMA: Yes. It starts small, but as it rolls, it gets huge and fast.

JOSH: Soon nothing can stop it.

EMMA: The red marks build my snowball.

JOSH: By keeping it quiet, you protect it from the hot sun.

EMMA: And once my snowball is huge, then I let people see it. Because by then, a wet log cannot stop a massive snowball. It just gets crushed.

JOSH: I want to crush wet logs with my giant snowball of success.

EMMA: This is the perfect time for our comment ask.

JOSH: Yes, we want to hear from you right now.

EMMA: We will start a line and we want you to finish it in the comments.

JOSH: So the line is, this week I will take one quiet step toward my goal, and that step is—

EMMA: Leave your answer below. Tell us the small, silent action you will take.

JOSH: Do not name the grand plan. Just name the quiet step.

EMMA: I love that. Back to the quiet way. Doing work in the dark sounds lonely.

JOSH: It can feel lonely, but it is not about hiding forever. It is about waiting.

EMMA: Waiting for what exactly?

JOSH: Waiting until your roots are deep, like a strong tree in the dirt.

EMMA: When your roots are thin, a simple question can pull your plan out.

JOSH: Are you sure about this, Josh? And boom, my tree falls.

EMMA: The quiet way builds thick roots.

JOSH: You become your own fan. I will stand in my room and clap for my red X marks.

EMMA: Your own pride lasts much longer than quick online likes.

JOSH: We stop asking the crowd. We start asking ourselves.

EMMA: That leads us to point 6.

JOSH: The trap of looking. Looking at what?

EMMA: Even if you stay quiet, you might look at what others are doing online.

JOSH: I do this a lot. I see folks doing the exact thing I want to do.

EMMA: How does that make you feel?

JOSH: Small. I see a guy playing a fast guitar solo and I want to quit.

EMMA: That is the trap. You put your day 1 beside someone's year 3.

JOSH: My day 1 beside his year 3. That is so unfair to me.

EMMA: The bright screens make us do it. We see the final result.

JOSH: We forget the quiet years they spent in the dark cave.

EMMA: When you see their win, you might seek quick validation.

JOSH: Validation. That is another big word. What does it mean?

EMMA: Validation is needing someone else to say, you are good, you matter.

JOSH: I admit, I love getting a gold star from my peers.

EMMA: Seeking validation on day 1 is a huge trap. You focus on the show.

JOSH: So if I see the guitar guy, I should turn off the screen?

EMMA: Yes, turn it off. Go practice your basic chords. Finish your day 1.

JOSH: It is hard to look away. The apps want to keep me scrolling.

EMMA: Guard your eyes as much as you guard your mouth.

JOSH: Keep my mouth shut. Keep my eyes on my paper. A solid plan.

EMMA: If a friend opens a shop and sells 10 cakes, do not rush.

JOSH: I would want to buy a huge oven just to keep up with her.

EMMA: That rush makes you skip the early steps. You waste money.

JOSH: I need to be blind to her cakes so I do not rush my own pace.

EMMA: Silence and blindness go hand in hand at the start.

JOSH: I am like a wise old monk on a quiet mountain.

EMMA: Now let us wind things down with vocab unwind.

JOSH: The part where we review the big words we used today.

EMMA: Word number 1 is unsolicited. Repeat after me: unsolicited.

JOSH: Unsolicited.

EMMA: Unsolicited. It means getting advice you did not ask for.

JOSH: My aunt gave me unsolicited advice about my shoes today.

EMMA: Word number 2 is validation. Repeat after me: validation.

JOSH: Validation.

EMMA: Validation. It means seeking praise or a gold star to feel good.

JOSH: I posted a selfie just to get some quick validation from pals.

EMMA: Word number three is accountability. Repeat after me: accountability,

JOSH: accountability,

EMMA: accountability. It means having someone check your real progress and hold you to your word.

JOSH: I need accountability, so my coach texts me every dawn.

EMMA: Word number four is selectivity. Repeat after me: selectivity.

JOSH: Selectivity.

EMMA: Selectivity. It means being very picky about who you share your secrets with.

JOSH: I use selectivity. I only tell my big dreams to my dog.

EMMA: Word number five is momentum. Repeat after me. Momentum.

JOSH: Momentum.

EMMA: Momentum. It means the force that keeps a moving object going strong.

JOSH: The momentum made my third day of running feel very easy.

EMMA: Word number 6 is stagnation. Repeat after me: stagnation.

JOSH: Stagnation.

EMMA: Stagnation. It means feeling stuck in one place, like water that does not flow.

JOSH: I felt deep stagnation at my desk, so I made a change.

EMMA: Great job! Let us move to point 8, say it better.

JOSH: Point 8, hit me with plain talk and I will make it fancy.

EMMA: We have 4 plain lines. Upgrade them aloud, one at a time. Start with, I need someone to check on me.

JOSH: Upgraded, I need some accountability from a true friend.

EMMA: Good. Sentence 2: She gave me advice I did not ask for.

JOSH: Upgraded: She gave me unsolicited advice at the party.

EMMA: Yes. Sentence 3: I only share plans with a chosen few.

JOSH: Upgraded: I use strict selectivity when I share my goals.

EMMA: Perfect. Sentence 4: I feel stuck in the mud at work.

JOSH: Upgraded: I am trapped in a state of stagnation at work.

EMMA: You nailed all 4.

JOSH: Using the right words makes your speech sharp.

EMMA: It feels good to use the right tool for the job.

JOSH: We have reached point 9.

EMMA: The quiet step. The big payoff where we wrap it all up.

JOSH: We asked you earlier to name your quiet step in the comments. We all have one plan we talk about more than we build.

EMMA: Yes. Your quiet step is the cure. You take the energy from your mouth,

JOSH: And I put that energy right into my hands. Stop talking, start doing.

EMMA: Instead of talking about a book, write one page in the dark.

JOSH: Instead of posting about a diet, drink a glass of water quietly.

EMMA: Build it in the dark and let the results make the noise later.

JOSH: Let the massive snowball do the talking for me.

EMMA: Before we wrap up, let us do a quick silent listening check.

JOSH: Just in your own head, folks. No stress at all.

EMMA: Ask yourself, how much of today's chat did you get? Score yourself 50%, 70%, or nearly all.

JOSH: There's no need to be perfect. It is not a test. It is good practice for your English.

EMMA: Time for a short recap. Point 1, talking a plan away costs it its push. You lose your drive.

JOSH: Yep. Keep the fizz inside the bottle.

EMMA: Point 2.

JOSH: The tell trap makes the work heavy because you owe them a show.

EMMA: Do not hand out microphones to your family. Point 3.

JOSH: The quiet way builds true momentum against their stagnation.

EMMA: You fit the big words right into the recap. Very slick. Thank you for joining us today. Please take care of your family and come back next week.

JOSH: Do not forget to leave a like and hit subscribe before you go.

EMMA: Have a great week and keep your plans quiet.

Vocab Unwind

6 key words and phrases from this episode

#	WORD	MEANING	ANALOGY	EXAMPLE
1	**unsolicited**	Getting advice you did not ask for.	Like a stranger telling you how to park your own car.	*My aunt gave me unsolicited advice about my shoes today.*
2	**validation**	Seeking praise or a gold star to feel good.	A gold star you stick on your own hand.	*I posted a selfie just to get some quick validation from pals.*
3	**accountability**	Having someone check your real progress and hold you to your word.	A friend who checks your homework every week.	*I need accountability, so my coach texts me every dawn.*
4	**selectivity**	Being very picky about who you share your secrets with.	A key you only give to two people.	*I use selectivity. I only tell my big dreams to my dog.*
5	**momentum**	The force that keeps a moving object going strong.	A snowball getting bigger as it rolls down a hill.	*The momentum made my third day of running feel very easy.*
6	**stagnation**	Feeling stuck in one place, like water that does not flow.	A pond with no river running through it.	*I felt deep stagnation at my desk, so I made a change.*